CHAPTER EIGHT

The Postcolonial Jew: Racialization, Delegitimization, Ambiguity

Efraim Sicher

UNDERSTANDING THE NARRATIVE

The self-hating Jew Sam Finkler, in Howard Jacobson's Booker prize-winning novel *The Finkler Question* (2010), has reminded us that if supporters of Israel do not understand the narrative of their opponents, they will never win the argument: "You win by understanding something of what the other side thinks, and they understand nothing."[1] It is imperative to examine the underlying reasons why Israel has been delegitimized in a mainstream public discourse that identifies with an anti-racist liberal progressive platform. This discourse neutralizes opponents with a straw man argument which says that any criticism of "Israel" is accused of being antisemitic by Israel's supporters, who then allegedly play the antisemitic card in order to shut down the debate over the Middle East conflict.[2] It is a discourse underpinned by fundamental ideological positions in postcolonial theory, usually identified with "common sense" opinions espoused widely by the European and some of the Israeli Left. Grounded in Gramscian political theory and neo-Marxism, these positions form a major opinion shaper in cultural studies and liberal progressive politics.

JEWS AS COLONIZED/COLONIALS

The Jews could be seen themselves as "colonial subjects" within European states, who were treated for hundreds of years as alien Others (often with second-class citizenship or no civic rights), yet who successfully reclaimed their ancestral homeland from British rule. The anomalies of their status in the Diaspora sometimes caused resentment of the Jews' exclusivity and particularism, or raised suspicions of their involvement in a conspiracy to undermine the economy or control the press. Yet when we analyze the discourses about the "Jews" as a construct of the Western imagination, an

Copyright © 2016. Nebraska. All rights reserved.

Anti-Judaism, Antisemitism, and Delegitimizing Israel, Nebraska, 2016. ProQuest Ebook Central,